



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: 10 th May ,2026	Entry: #1
Description	A security incident took place at 9:00am where employees reported they could not use their computers to access files such as medical files.
Tool(s) used	None.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who A group of Malicious unethical hackers ● What Ransomware event ● When Tuesday at 9:00am ● Where US based Healthcare Organization ● Why? At 9:00am on Tuesday, employees reported they were unable to use their computers to access files. A group of malicious hackers used phishing as their social engineering tool to install ransomware onto an employee's device. Once it was installed, the ransomware encrypted the file data of the business entity, and demanded funds be sent to them in return for the decryption key. One cause for this incident was the lack of employee training on the different types of social engineering attacks.

Additional notes	Employers can mitigate these types of attacks by providing adequate employee training on social engineering attacks.
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Date: 20 th June, 2026	Entry: #2
Description	Employee downloaded a password protected attachment from a phishing email.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who Malicious actor ● What Employee opened a phishing email ● When 20th June, 2026 at 1:13pm ● Where Financial Services Company ● Why At 1:20pm, I received an IDS alert of a suspicious file being downloaded on an employee's computer. Upon investigating, I discovered that an employee opened a phishing email and downloaded a password protected attachment from this email. When they opened the file, it executed malicious code on the employee's computer. I created a SHA256 hash of the malicious file. I ran the file hash of the downloaded file on VirusTotal, which helped me analyze the file for malicious content like trojans and viruses. The file was reported to be malicious by over 50 different vendors. The file was also known as a malware called Flagpro. This incident took place in the Detection and Analysis phase. What led to this incident was the lack of adequate employee training on phishing and Social Engineering attacks.

Additional notes	The Organization should implement prevention factors like employee training on Social Engineering scams such as phishing.
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Date: 20 th June, 2026	Entry: # 3
Description	Employee downloaded a malicious file, after verifying it was indeed malicious, I must follow my Organization's process to complete and resolve my investigation
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who unknown ● What A phishing attempt of a malicious actor with a malicious file attachment and a file hash 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b ● When 20th June, 2026 at 1:16pm ● Where Computer of employee at Financial Services Center company ● Why After investigating a phishing email that was downloaded by an employee, and utilizing VirusTotal, I created a virtual machine that ensured isolation from my Organization's network to further investigate the alert by following my Organization's Phishing Playbook. During the Investigation, I noticed the email was sent from an email address with names that were not consistent. The email address read "76tguyhh6tgftrtg.su", but the name that was used in the email body read "Clyde West", and the sender name read "Def Communications".

	The subject of the email, as well as the email body had many grammatical errors. Furthermore, the email body had a password protected attachment, which was proven to be malicious and verified on VirusTotal. I have chosen to raise this alert ticket as 'Escalated' to a level 2 SOC analyst.
Additional notes	Severity of the known malicious file was rated as 'Medium'. The ticket ID is A-2703. Employee training on Social Engineering attacks are highly recommended.

Date: 28 th June, 2026	Entry: #4
Description	A malicious actor stole PII data, and demanded \$50k in exchange for not releasing the data to the public.
Tool(s) used	none
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who Malicious actor ● What Attacker stole PII data and demanded cryptocurrency ● When 28th June, 2026 at 7:20pm PT ● Where E-commerce web application of the Organization ● Why At 7:20pm on 28th June, 2026, an employee received an email from an attacker who claimed that they gained access to the company's PII data and demanded money in exchange to not leak the sensitive data. After their investigation, the security team concluded the cause of the incident was a vulnerability in the e-commerce web

	application. This vulnerability allowed the attacker to conduct a forced browsing attack by modifying the order number included in the URL string of the purchase confirmation page, thus granting them access to PII data. I have now been tasked with reviewing the Final report, as part of the Post-incident Activity phase o NIST Incident Response Lifecycle. Upon reviewing, the organization Recommended implementation of routine vulnerability scans and access control mechanisms to prevent future reoccurrences.
Additional notes	One of the impacts this has on an organization is their reputation.

Date: 7 th , July 2026	Entry: #5
Description	Analyzing Live network traffic from a Linux virtual machine.
Tool(s) used	I used a network protocol analyzer, tcpdump. This tool helps analysts like myself in capturing, filtering, and analyzing network traffic. You can access tcpdump through the command line interface.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who N/A ● What N/A ● When N/A ● Where N/A ● Why N/A

Additional notes	Using the tcpdump tool is highly valuable. I know that with repeated exposure will strengthen my expertise level for this skill.
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Date: 7 th July, 2026	Entry: #6
Description	Analyzing a packet capture file (pcap).
Tool(s) used	To analyze a packet capture file, I used the cybersecurity tool called Wireshark. It is also a network analyzer tool, but instead of accessing it via the CLI, Wireshark uses GUI, a graphical user interface. Wireshark also allows analysts like myself to capture, and analyze traffic on a network.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. ● Who ● What ● When ● Where ● Why
Additional notes	Wireshark is definitely easier on the eyes. I do like the hacker feeling that using CLI based network protocol analyzer tools give off. But both are great tools.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes: Record additional notes.

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?

Not exactly. There were activities that were new to me, but after some hands on practice labs and re-reading the exemplars, I became familiar with them. The most frustrating in the beginning was the case sensitivity. I would type out a syntax, but it would read error because of the case sensitivity. After a few times of this issue, I now know and easily remember to carefully spell out what I intend in on the CLI.

2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?

Yes. Taking this course made me really appreciate the cybersecurity field and has given me exposure to a reality I did not fully comprehend when it comes to the importance of data security. The importance of choosing a secure password, and also opting in for MFA, and the high importance of educating oneself on Social Engineering are important lessons and knowledge to keep oneself protected from all the dangers that lurk in the tech world. I grew to appreciate the concepts and frameworks that are put in place by security professionals such as the C.I.A Triad, and the NIST Cybersecurity framework, and how organizations are working daily to protect our sensitive data and identity from malicious attackers.

3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?

I really enjoyed all of the hands-on lab. I especially liked using the CLI on the Linux bash and being able to use that just as effectively as using the GUI for accessing things like documents, renaming them, moving them, and deleting them. I also really liked the security principles theory like Least Privilege, and defense in depth. I think that some of these knowledges are knowledge that are simple, and highly advantageous, yet perhaps not many implement them or know them.